

Thursday, 20 August 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Heavy drizzle

22° 16°

BIRMINGHAM

Drizzle

19° 14°

MANCHESTER

Rain

18° 14°

GLASGOW

Light rain

16° 13°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1 Russia has issued a new threat to the UK, with Prime Minister Andy Burnham confirming London will continue "to support Ukraine 100%."**
This comes amidst escalating tensions, as Russia has previously made veiled threats towards countries aiding Ukraine. The UK's unwavering support for Ukraine remains a key point of contention.
POLITICS · UK

- 2 Scientists are reportedly 'stunned' by the recovery of children's lung capacity in an ultra-low emission zone.**
A new study shows that children's lungs caught up with their peers in less polluted areas after a clean air zone was introduced. This highlights the significant health benefits of reducing vehicle emissions.
ENVIRONMENT · UK

- 3 Competition for degree apprenticeships has quadrupled as the cost of traditional university education continues to rise.**
The increasing popularity of these apprenticeships reflects a growing trend towards alternative routes to higher education. Many are seeking to avoid the significant financial burden of university fees.
EDUCATION · UK

- 4 A government minister has admitted that lessons need to be learned from the recent devastating wildfires across the UK.**
Six major blazes continue to burn in South Wales, with military support being withdrawn. The widespread fires have highlighted the urgent need for better preparedness and response strategies.
ENVIRONMENT · UK

- 5 Police have launched a double murder investigation after two men were found dead in a flat in Glasgow.**
The bodies of Paul Lafferty and Gary Beaton were discovered on Sunday in Patrick's Chancellor Street. Detectives are appealing for anyone with information to come forward.
CRIME · UK

What's coming up

1 **Reading Festival has been granted a music extension this month, despite some concerns about noise from local residents.**

Charli XCX, rapper Dave, and Chase & Status are set to headline the popular festival. This extension means even more music for festival-goers.

ON AIR – Are you heading to Reading Festival this year, or do you live nearby? What do you think about the noise concerns?

MUSIC · THIS MONTH

2 **The National Television Awards have made history by selecting an all-female shortlist for the drama acting award.**

The five-strong list features Ella Bruccoleri, Sheridan Smith, Ruth Jones, Vicky McClure, and Judy Parfitt. It's a fantastic recognition of female talent in British drama.

ON AIR – Who do you think deserves to win the NTA for best drama actress this year?

AWARDS · COMING UP

3 **Earl Spencer is set to 'tell the truth' about his sister Princess Diana in a new book, due out next month.**

Titled 'Swan Song: Diana, My Sister,' the book comes nearly 30 years after her death. It promises a deeply personal account from her brother.

ON AIR – What are your expectations for Earl Spencer's new book about Princess Diana?

BOOKS · NEXT MONTH

4 **Kanye West has announced a series of tour dates in Russia, making him the first major Western artist to play there since the invasion of Ukraine.**

This move has generated significant discussion given the ongoing geopolitical situation. Fans are reacting to the controversial decision.

ON AIR – What do you make of Kanye West's decision to tour in Russia?

MUSIC · COMING UP

5 **Beninese musical icon Angélique Kidjo has made history by receiving a star on the Hollywood Walk of Fame.**

The 66-year-old singer emphasized the global impact of African music, stating, "Without Africans, no music is possible on this planet." It's a well-deserved honour.

ON AIR – Which African artists do you think deserve more global recognition?

AWARDS · THIS WEEK

On the schedule

1 England's Ollie Robinson made an immediate impact in the first Test against Pakistan, taking a wicket with the very first ball.

Robinson trapped Azan Awaiz lbw at Headingley, giving England the perfect start to the match. It was a dream beginning for the bowler.

ON AIR – What's the most exciting start to a cricket match you've ever seen?

CRICKET · UK

2 Sheffield United could face a significant 12-point deduction after the company used to buy the club was placed into liquidation.

This High Court ruling casts a shadow over the start of their season. It could have a major impact on their Premier League campaign.

ON AIR – How much do points deductions truly affect a club's performance and morale?

FOOTBALL · UK

3 Carlos Sainz has committed his future to Williams, signing a new contract that will keep him with the F1 team into 2027 and beyond.

This is great news for Williams, securing a 'leader' in Sainz for the coming seasons. It shows confidence in the team's direction.

ON AIR – Which F1 driver do you think is the most valuable asset to their team?

F1 · UK

4 Aston Villa have confirmed two new signings, bringing in goalkeeper Zion Suzuki and left-back Matteo Ruggeri in deals worth a combined £47m.

These significant additions bolster Villa's squad as they prepare for the new season. Fans will be eager to see them in action.

ON AIR – Which new Premier League signing are you most excited to see play this season?

FOOTBALL · UK

5 Red Bull's Isack Hadjar will miss this weekend's Dutch Grand Prix after injuring his wrist during the summer break.

This is a setback for Hadjar and the Red Bull team. It means a change to the driver lineup for the upcoming race.

ON AIR – How much does a driver's absence impact an F1 team's performance for a single race?

F1 · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A recent study suggests that listening to the gentle rumble of a washing machine can be surprisingly soothing.**
Apparently, the consistent, low-frequency hum of household appliances like tumble dryers or dishwashers can mimic white noise, helping some people relax or even drift off to sleep. Who knew chores could be so calming?
- 2 The delightful art of 'doodling' during meetings or phone calls might actually be a sign of increased focus, not distraction.**
Researchers found that people who doodle can recall more information from spoken presentations than those who don't. So, next time you see someone sketching, they might just be paying more attention!
- 3 The charming tradition of 'leaving out books for others to find' in public spaces is growing.**
Known as 'bookcrossing', this lovely movement encourages people to share stories by leaving books with notes for strangers to discover, read, and then pass on. It's like a treasure hunt for literature!
- 4 New findings indicate that 'gazing at the stars' can inspire feelings of wonder and perspective.**
Experts suggest that taking a moment to look up at the night sky helps put daily worries into perspective and fosters a sense of connection to something much bigger. All you need is a clear night and perhaps a cuppa!
- 5 The simple joy of 'building a den' is experiencing a heartwarming resurgence among families.**
Whether it's blankets over chairs indoors or branches in the garden, creating a cosy hideaway offers a fantastic chance for imaginative play and bonding away from screens. A bit of old-fashioned fun, eh?
- 6 A study found that 'listening to the rain' can have a profoundly calming effect on the human mind.**
The natural, rhythmic sound of raindrops is often used in relaxation apps, and now research backs up what many of us already feel – it's wonderfully peaceful. Perfect for a quiet afternoon indoors.
- 7 The delightful pastime of 'collecting interesting pebbles' from beaches and riverbanks is becoming a popular hobby.**
People are finding joy in searching for unique shapes, colours, and textures. It's a wonderful way to enjoy the outdoors, and you end up with a lovely, free collection of natural art!

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 70% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to quickly judge the temperature outside, even if it's just peeking through a window?

ANSWER: ...STICKING JUST ONE HAND OUT THE DOOR OR WINDOW TO TEST THE AIR!

Q Our survey said that over 65% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a lovely, fresh cup of coffee. What is it?

ANSWER: ...ALWAYS MAKING SURE THE SPOON IS PLACED JUST SO ON THE SAUCER, EVEN IF NO ONE ELSE IS LOOKING!

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes you discover a 'secret shortcut' in your local area that saves you loads of time, or helps you avoid traffic?**

Perhaps it's a little alleyway, a forgotten footpath, or a clever route only the locals know. What's your best secret shortcut, and how did you discover it?

- **We all have those 'little rituals' that mark the start of a new season, don't we?**

Maybe it's swapping over your wardrobe, changing your duvet, or a particular meal you make. What are your personal rituals that tell you a new season has arrived?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** A group of owls is called a 'parliament'.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Butterflies taste with their antennae, which helps them find nectar.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£42 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£42 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The inventor of the Pringle's can is buried in one.
- The 'sixth sick sheik's sixth sheep's sick' is thought to be the toughest tongue twister in the English language.
- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are over 3,000 years old and still perfectly edible.
- A day on Venus is longer than a year on Venus.
- The Eiffel Tower can be 15 cm taller during the summer due to thermal expansion of the iron.
- The sound of a duck's quack does not echo, and no one knows why.
- There are more possible iterations of a game of chess than there are atoms in the known universe.
- Cleopatra lived closer in time to the invention of the iPhone than to the building of the Great Pyramid of Giza.

On this day

Day 232 of the year, 133 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Amadour; Christian feast day: Bernard of Clairvaux; Christian feast day: Blessed Georg Häfner; Christian feast day: Heliodorus of Bet Zabdai. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1986 — Andrew Surman, South African-English footballer
- 1975 — Shaun Newton, English footballer
- 1974 — Amy Adams, American actress
- 1976 — Tony Grant, Irish footballer
- 1941 — Dave Brock, English singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1977 — Wayne Brown, English footballer
- 1979 — Jamie Cullum, English singer-songwriter and pianist
- 1989 — Judd Trump, English snooker player

THE DAY TODAY

- 1988 — The Troubles: Eight British soldiers are killed and 28 wounded when their bus is hit by an IRA roadside bomb in Ballygawley, County Tyrone.
- 2016 — Fifty-four people are killed when a suicide bomber detonates himself at a Kurdish wedding party in Gaziantep, Turkey.
- 2006 — Sri Lankan Civil War: Sri Lankan Tamil politician and former MP S. Sivamaharajah is shot dead at his home in Tellippalai.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1905 — Sun Yat-sen, Song Jiaoren, and others establish the Tongmenghui, a Republican, anti-Qing revolutionary organisation, in Tokyo, Japan.
- 1991 — Dissolution of the Soviet Union, August Coup: More than 100,000 people rally outside the Soviet Union's parliament building protesting the coup aiming to depose President Mikhail Gorbachev.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 2006 — Sri Lankan Civil War: Sri Lankan Tamil politician and former MP S. Sivamaharajah is shot dead at his home in Tellippalai.

- 1998 — The Supreme Court of Canada rules that Quebec cannot legally secede from Canada without the federal government's approval.
- 1968 — Cold War: Warsaw Pact troops invade Czechoslovakia, crushing the Prague Spring. East German participation is limited to a few specialists due to memories of the recent war. Only Albania and Romania refuse to participate.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 233 of the year, 132 days left in 2026. Today Christian Feast Day: Abraham of Smolensk (Eastern Orthodox Church); Christian Feast Day: Bernard of Alzira; Christian Feast Day: Cyriaca; Christian Feast Day: Euprepus of Verona. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1975 — Alicia Witt, American actress and musician
- 1941 — Jackie DeShannon, American singer-songwriter
- 1988 — Kacey Musgraves, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1993 — Millie Bright, English footballer
- 1956 — Kim Cattrall, English-Canadian actress
- 1949 — Loretta Devine, American actress and singer
- 1971 — Liam Howlett, English keyboard player, DJ, and producer
- 1989 — Hayden Panettiere, American actress (died 2026)

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2000 — American golfer Tiger Woods wins the 82nd PGA Championship and becomes the first golfer since Ben Hogan in 1953 to win three majors in a calendar year.
- 1945 — Physicist Harry Daghljan is fatally irradiated in a criticality accident during an experiment with the Demon core at Los Alamos National Laboratory.
- 1988 — The 6.9 Mw Nepal earthquake shakes the Nepal–India border with a maximum Mercalli intensity of VIII (Severe), leaving 709–1,450 people killed and thousands injured.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1140 — Song dynasty general Yue Fei defeats an army led by Jin dynasty general Wuzhu at the Battle of Yancheng during the Jin–Song Wars.
- 1942 — World War II: The Guadalcanal campaign: American forces defeat an attack by Imperial Japanese Army soldiers in the Battle of the Tenaru.

Coming to cinemas

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome
SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar

AUGUST 2026

22–23

Belgian Grand Prix (F1)